

Fate's Edge

The Amaranthine Core

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(with apologies to the sea)

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Preface: The Tide-Clerk's Ledger

I was born on the mudflats, which is to say I was born with salt in my blood and a deficit in my soul. My mother kept the beacon at Deadman's Point. My father was a reef – that is to say, he took more ships than he saved. I learned to read the tide before I learned my letters, and I learned that the sea does not forgive arithmetic errors.

But arithmetic is only one kind of account. A promise carved in stone, a red thread tied at a crossroads, a cup left empty for a guest who never arrives – these are also contracts, though no ledger records them. The Amaranthine runs on three ledgers: the Admiralty's tariff books, the Syndicate's invisible-ink manifests, and the sea's own memory – the one carved in wreckage and coral.

Some call it debt. I call it *what remains when the tide goes out*.

This book is not a travel guide. It is a collection of thresholds: bridges that remember every toll, fog-bells that count your breaths, stones that warm when you speak a true name. Use the cards to generate scenes. Let the fiction lead. When you are lost, ask: *What does this place owe? And to whom?*

— *A Tide-Clerk of no fixed abode, whose abacus has nine beads and who has never balanced a single account*

How to Use This Book

This book is a toolkit for the Game Master. Each regional chapter contains:

- A short atmosphere paragraph and a local quote.
- An *almanac* – a quick Q&A about daily life in that region.
- A full set of card-driven generator tables (♠ *places*, ♥ *people*, ♣ *complications*, ♦ *rewards*). *Tousethen*

For the full card system, see **The Cartomancer's Compass** (next chapter). For mechanical rules (attributes, skills, actions, magic, summoning), refer to the *Fate's Edge System Reference Document*.

The Cartomancer's Compass

The Ledger of the Deck

The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.

The regional generators in this book from the fog-choked levees of the Mistlands (chap:mistlands) to the walking cities of Ngomebe (chap:ngomebe) all speak the same language: the language of the fifty-two-card deck. Learn to read it, and you can generate a campaign, a crossroads, or a crisis in the time it takes to shuffle.

This chapter is your key. It explains how to interpret any card drawn from any regional generator, and how to weave those interpretations into the fiction at your table. Consider it the threshold between the abstract mechanics of the draw and the living, breathing world of Fate's Edge.

The Four Suits: A Universal Grammar

Every card in every generator carries the same four suit-meanings. They are the alphabet of the world's ledger.

0.0.1 ♠ *Spades : PlaceTheStage*

Where does the scene happen? ♠ *isthethreshold,thelandmark,thegroundbeneaththeaction.Itanswers : Where are we?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A major landmark a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A functional location a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A liminal or neglected place a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smuggler's cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, ♠ *entriesarealwaysplaces.See, forexample, thebridgesandcanalsofSilkstran*

0.0.2 ♡ *Hearts : ActorTheFace*

Who drives the scene? ♡ *istheperson, thefaction, thevoicethatspeaks.Itanswers : Who is here?*

- **High rank (J–A):** An elite, a ruler, a power-broker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, ♡ *entriesarealwayspeopleor factions.SeethemerchantsandspiesoftheBrassC*
wardensoftheMistlands(sec : mistlands – people).

0.0.3 ♣ *Clubs : PressureTheComplication*

What pushes back? ♣ *isthestorm, thedebt, theknifeinthedark.Itanswers : What goes wrong?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A serious obstacle a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor hazard a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, ♣ *entriesarealwayscomplicationsorthreats.Seetheriverfloodsandwitness–*
cordcutsofAyokha(sec : ayokha – complications)orthemarketriotsofSilkstrand(sec : silkstrand – comp

0.0.4 ◇ *Diamonds : LeverageTheReward*

What opens the door? ◇ *isthetoken, thewrit, thesecretthatchangesPosition.Itanswers : What do you gain?*

- **High rank (J–A):** A major asset a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the party's standing.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A significant tool a pass-stone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor advantage a bridge token, a guest-cup, a rumour. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, ◇ *entriesarealwaysrewardsorleverage.SeethekeystonechartersofNgomebe(s*
sharetabletsofFhara(sec : fhara – rewards).

Rank and Severity: The Weight of the Card

The rank of a card from Ace (high) to 2 (low) sets the scale of its suit's meaning. Use this ladder:

Rank	Narrative Weight
Ace	Legendary, campaign-altering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, faction-level, lasting consequences
10–7	Significant, scene-defining, costly
6–4	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
3–2	Minor, a complication but not a crisis

When a generator instructs you to set a clock by the highest rank, use this conversion:

- **2–5:** 4-segment clock (short, local problem)
- **6–10:** 6-segment clock (standard, journey-length)
- **J, Q, K:** 8-segment clock (extended, regional problem)
- **A:** 10-segment clock (epic, campaign-length)

Card Faces: The Court as Character

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name.

- **Jack:** An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else's authority. They are competent but replaceable.
- **Queen:** A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced.
- **King:** The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a ♡ (*actor*) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears as a King of Clubs might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers

Aces and the Ninth: The Hollow's Attention

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (see sec:theona-mechanics, sec:aelinnel-mechanics, sec:ways-between-features), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

- In Theona (chap:theona), an Ace of ♠ *mightaddamissingstepptoabridge*.
- In the Ways Between (chap:ways-between), an Ace of ♥ *mightcauseareflectiontospeak*.
- In the Mistlands (chap:mistlands), an Ace of ♣ *mightcauseabell – linetofail*.

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

By the Numbers: Procedure for Any Generator

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure:

1. **Name the destination.** Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate?
2. **Shuffle and draw.** Draw cards face-up, one for each suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three.
3. **Read the ♠.** *This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage.*
3. **Read the ♥.** *This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here?*
3. **Read the ♣.** *This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to?*
3. **Read the ♦.** *This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific.*
3. **Set the clock.** Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scene's primary clock (see sec:rank-severity).
4. **Interpret faces and Aces.** Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects.
5. **Play to find out.** Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

Regional Flavours: How Suits Shift Meaning

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture.

A ♠ *in Ektoria* (chap : ektoria) *is a forum or a coin – house*; a ♠ *in the Valewood* (chap : valewood) *is a phasing road*. A ♥ *in the Black Banners* (chap : black – banners) *is a mercenary captain or a condottabroker*; a ♥ *in Ykr* *singer*.

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table (e.g., sec:acasia-places for Acasia, sec:oshiira-people for Oshiira). The table will give you a specific entry keyed to the rank and suit. Do not invent from scratch unless the table runs out – the tables are designed to evoke the specific flavour of the region.

Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches (chap:acasia). You draw:

♠ 7, ♥ J, ♣ 4, ♦ Q

1. ♠ 7 : *Youconsultsec : acasia – places.A7ofSpadesis1Hill–MotteFreshpalisade;ditchscatteredwith*

1. ♥ J : *Youconsultsec : acasia – people.AJackofHeartsis1BridewithNoDowrybutaClaim–Daggersis*

1. ♣ 4 : *Youconsultsec : acasia – complications.A4ofClubsis1WeddingTurnsAmbush–Youarecaught*

1. ♦ Q : *Youconsultsec : acasia – rewards.AQueenofDiamondsis1MarriageProxy–FromtheMarga*

1. **Highest rank: Queen** (rank equivalent to King/J/Q at 8). The scene's primary clock is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates [8]*.
2. **Interpretation:** The party arrives at a hill-fort (Hill-Motte) on the eve of a wedding. The bride (Bride with No Dowry) is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence (Wedding Turns Ambush). If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy — a powerful tool to bind a hill-king to their cause. The 8-segment clock tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

The Unwritten Suit: When a Draw is Incomplete

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg, for example, may only need ♠, ♥, ♣ (*seesec : globaltravel – procedure*). *Asocialencounter might only need ♥ and ♣. When a suit is missing*

- **No ♠** : *The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space – across roads, a fork in the road, a bank, at a threshold.*
- **No ♥** : *The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frigid.*

- **No ♣** : *The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straight forward. This is rare in Fate's Edge. Treasures are hidden, but not lost.*
- **No ♦** : *The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared cloak.*

Interpreting Any Draw, Any Region

When you need a prompt in a hurry — a random encounter, a rumour at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin — draw a single card. Use this quick-reference:

♠	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
♥	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
♣	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
♦	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollow's attention.

This single-card method is ideal for improvisation. It gives you one clear element to build around. Let the fiction answer the rest.

Final Guidance: The Cards Are Oracles, Not Scripts

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret debt.

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

"The ledger is never closed. It is only passed to the next keeper." — Dusana of the Raven Road

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest – ask which hull leaks slowest.” —
Dusana of the Raven Road

For the GM – The Spider, the Snake, the Raven

The three Omens (**Inaea**, **Isoka**, **Ikasha**) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes:

- A rope that never frays (Inaea)
- A judgment that cuts clean (Isoka)
- A dream that feels too real (Ikasha)

By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens – the Clockwork Demon, the scouring of civilisations, Ikasha’s imprisonment in Obishaal – is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs:

- If players ask a Pereshi fire-keeper about the “serpent judge,” they will receive a riddle.
- If they ask a Tulkani about the “dreamer,” they will receive a story.
- If they ask a Sidhi about the “spider,” they will receive a knot and a warning: *“Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.”*

The Hollow is the interest on the Omens’ oldest debt. The players are never meant to pay it off – only to decide whose name goes on the next line of the ledger.

Gateways & Travel

The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths.

Travel Modes of the Amaranthine

Sea Legs

The Amaranthine Sea connects Kahfagia, Ecktoria, Acasia, and the northern coasts. Controlling authority is either the origin port's navy or a neutral convoy league. Passage requires a **Lantern Code** (Kahfagia) or a **Convoy Letter** stamped with the Admiral's seal. Without papers, you sail at your own risk – the reefs are hungry.

Mountain Passes & Underways

Aeler holds and the Mistlands are linked by the **Spine Underway**, a great tunnel beneath the peaks. Travel requires an **Underway Pass** and a breath-counter – count to eight, never nine. The Mistlands' bell-lines are navigable only by those carrying **ward-salt**.

River Legs

The Belworth (Vhasia/Viterra) and the Dolmis (eastern coast) are arteries of trade and conflict. Crossing requires a **Safe-Conduct** recognised on both banks. The Theona taboos (no ninth step, no ninth cup) apply on river bridges.

Steppe Legs

The Violet Steppe (Ykrul) and the eastern grasslands (Kuvani) use remount stations and grazing compacts. A **Hostage String** or a **Story Toll** buys passage. Never ride between two wolves at dusk – that gap belongs to the Hollow.

Gateways to Other Expansions

- **Southern Realms (Oshiira, Ashaan, Ngomebe):** From Kahfagia, sail the **Narrow of Sorrows** to the Brass Coast. From Ecktoria, follow the Imperial Road south to the Sahel.

- **Way of Silk (Fhara, Sidhi, Pereshi, Kuvani, Tulkani):** From Ykrul, the **Eastern Steppe Road** leads to Kuvani remount stations. From Thepyrgos, caravans cross the Himadri passes to Pereshi highlands.
- **Eastern Realms (Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha):** From the Linns, sail the Aberderrin Sea to Nihori. From Acasia, follow the old Imperial Road east to Sihai.
- **Dhahara (Brass Coast, Nine Kingdoms, Himadri):** From Thepyrgos, the **Black River** leads south to the Brass Coast. From Aeler, the Himadri passes connect directly to the iron mines.

Part II

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest – ask which hull leaks slowest.”
— Dusana of the Raven Road (apocryphal)

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

Kahfagia is a thalassocracy of lantern-light and rust, where every beacon is a promise and every reef a debt collector. The Admiralty rules from its mirror-towers, but the true power flows through oligarchic families, privateers, and the silent threads of the Lethai-ar. Here, a well-placed lantern code can start a war – or end one.

“The commodores don’t want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too. I’ve seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she’d sold for a pilot’s license.”

— Captain Mira “the Lucky”, Sidhi exile

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridge – dried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchant – safe. Four means an Oshiiran grain barge – neutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernails – they bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn’t appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a “tariff surcharge.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not born – they are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell – the sound of their name. Offering it means “I give you my voice.” Refusing to return it is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral’s flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signal – never used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means "Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."

0.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your lamps trimmed and your signals clear. And if a gray-robed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free — say no. The Lethai-ar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signal-and-lane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise — or the harbor names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari — a thalassocracy where Oshiiran reckonings meet Vilikari tide-law. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly — and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethai-ar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirror-towers for decades. A factor’s trusted secretary, a harbor master’s silent wife, a pilot’s apprentice with too-still eyes — they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider’s mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone — admiral to dockhand — glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the Mirror-Keeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider’s brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil & The Spider’s Web

Power is visible here — literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to cede ground. To move a beacon is to declare war. Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-clocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet burial of a reputation.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethai-ar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented — they may be *woven*. A Mirror-Keeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider’s web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

p0.2p0.25p0.3p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
	Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.

Mirza al-Qasr Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe Control the tides through light Her face is never seen—only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.

Ximena Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar) Profit from every cargo, legal or not She keeps a hidden record in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.

Captain Rodrigo Privateer with a crooked letter of marque Raid the corsair fleet and keep his crew loyal His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.

Sister Anabel Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light) Tend the sick without asking for coin Her gray robes are said to be woven from old promises. They never stain.

Notary Farid Admiralty magistrate Resolve disputes before they reach the harbor master He carries a water-clock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.

The Veiled Harpist Lethai-ar infiltrator (secret) Weaving through the oligarchs, strand by strand No one knows her face. She plays only in mirror-lit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners' hair.

The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethai-ar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House al-Kassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethai-ar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethai-ar — they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply weighed down by Admiralty claims; the Lethai-ar are slowly gathering leverage.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty's own spy network — and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed — they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethai-ar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage — they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethai-ar’s long-term goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eight-shapes.
- A Mirror-Keeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower — a woman with chestnut-brown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a gray-robed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a Lethai-ar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny — and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the sea-faring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	al-Kassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>Tide-Keeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>Mirror-Eye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>Bell-Born</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>Ash-Sails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers’ shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Inspectors check the salt-scars — white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* ‘[TRADE]’

4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* '[STEALTH]'
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* '[TRAVEL]'
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow — the color of "maybe."* '[TRAVEL]'
7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* '[AUTHORITY]'
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs — the kind that skip the ninth beat.* '[LABOR]'
9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* '[WEATHER]'
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* '[SOCIAL]'
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water — today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* '[JUSTICE]'
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a voided manifest.* '[TRADE]'
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who bear heavy burdens.* '[DEATH]'

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *"The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope."* '[TRAVEL]'
3. **Pilot's Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow's navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* '[TRAVEL]'
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a manifest that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for "recent adjustments."* '[AUTHORITY]'
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two sets of books; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left column records bribes as "conciliation fees." The right one is never shown.* '[TRADE]'
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbor master listens anyway.* '[SOCIAL]'

7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a water-clock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen — only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs — once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelling** – a Lethai-ar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’
Someone bribed the tide-clerk — or the moon is angry.
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’
You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbor chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The chain’s links are inscribed with names of those who defied the Admiralty. Each one rattles differently.
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’
Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who — or drift into the reefs.
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; wages unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’
The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.

8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. '[COMBAT]'
Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper's badge — stolen or earned, you cannot tell.
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. '[JUSTICE]'
The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.
10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. '[DISASTER]'
A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. '[SOCIAL]'
The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. '[DEATH]'
The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else — something that smells sweet.
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — "Safe" corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. '[AUTHORITY]'
Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. '[WEATHER]'
[DEATH]' *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelling** — A Lethai-ar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. '[POLITICS]'
[FEAR]' *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbor favors you. '[TRAVEL]'
The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.
3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. '[TRAVEL]'
The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.
4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; no questions asked. '[TRADE]'
The clerk stamps it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.
5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. '[TRAVEL]'
The commodore's seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.
6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. '[TRADE]'
You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.
7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. '[TRADE]'
The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock — and breaks after use.

8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight's signals revealed; navigation advantage. '[TRAVEL]'
Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.
9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. '[AUTHORITY]'
The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favor.
10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. '[COMBAT]'
The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. '[JUSTICE]' *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tie it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. '[AUTHORITY]'
The Mirror-Keeper's seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law — until challenged.
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. '[TRADE]' *The share is a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.*
- A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. '[AUTHORITY]' *The harbor master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely — or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs — beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** — silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethai-ar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot's Mirror:** Kahfagia's strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4-segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and –1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chain-booms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).

- **Oligarchic Standing (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin weights, track *Standing* with the great families (al-Kassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Standing 1–3 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and off-the-books pilots. Standing 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safe-conduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethai-ar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethai-ar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled — and the new house head bows to a gray-robed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (requires spending 2 Standing).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** — The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the weight that the sea holds at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** — Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** — Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbor that exists only in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirror-towers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The Mirror-Keepers charge a fee for this service — payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethai-ar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a gray-robed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadow-kin, their records are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirror-tower shows only the face they wish to see — not the one that watches them sleep.

- **The Tide-Sworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only sworn promises. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman's Quay is run by gray-robed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, the sea remembers your name — and the sea never forgets. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order's good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window — waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-clockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take -1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark a *Burden* from the Tide Court. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web's Patience* tick. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbor where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding — until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs promises in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** — *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** — *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** — *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethai-ar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a promise older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves — and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of loyalty. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a gray-robed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access — to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethai-ar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being “woven,” or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Amaria — The Iron Shore

A small peninsula squeezed between Kahfagia’s Akilan holdings and the Oshiiran border, Amaria is a land of iron mines, coastal fog, and hybrid law. Ecktoria once claimed it; now it pays tribute to both Kahfagia and Oshiira to stay independent. Its people speak a creole of Kahfagian maritime slang and Oshiiran bureaucratic precision, and its courts rule by a blend of Admiralty tariff law and Vermilion Corps writ-law.

What you notice first: The smell of rust and brine. The way every official carries two seals — one for Kahfagia, one for Oshiira. The constant ticking of water-clocks that never agree on the hour.

The rule that kills newcomers: Never carry only one flag. Amarian vessels fly both the lantern and the grain sheaf. A single flag is a declaration of allegiance — and an invitation to be sunk by the other side.

Quick Generators for Amaria (d6 each)

Spades — Places (d6)

1. **Iron Quay** — A pier built from salvaged warship timbers. The nails are iron from the inland mines; they rust red, staining the water like blood. '[INDUSTRY]'
2. **Coin-House of Twin Books** — A counting-house where every transaction is recorded twice — once for the Kahfagian tariff, once for the Oshiiran grain tithe. The third book is the smuggler's. '[TRADE]'
3. **Fog Lighthouse (Disputed)** — A stone tower with two lamps: one green for Kahfagia, one white for Oshiira. Only one is lit at a time. The keeper changes them with the tide. '[AUTHORITY]'
4. **Smuggler's Rope-Walk** — A hidden cove where boats land at low tide. The rope-walk is a series of knotted lines that lead to a cave full of untaxed cargo. '[STEALTH]'
5. **Mine Shaft of the Ninth Vein** — An iron mine that goes deeper than the surveyors mapped. The miners whisper of a sealed door at the bottom — Aeler work, they say. '[MYSTERY]'
6. **Dual Customs Post** — A wooden shack with two windows: one for Kahfagian stamps, one for Oshiiran seals. The line snakes between them. Smugglers pay both clerks and skip the line. '[AUTHORITY]'

Hearts — People (d6)

1. **Twin-Book Clerk** — Sits at a split desk, writing with two hands. Her left hand files Kahfagian tariffs; her right, Oshiiran grain receipts. Her third hand — the one no one sees — writes the real numbers. '[TRADE]'
2. **Iron Miner (Free)** — A former indentured laborer who bought his freedom with a year's ore. His hands are stained red with rust. He knows the sealed door's location but will not speak of it. '[LABOR]'
3. **Smuggler Captain** — Flies no flag. His ship's name changes with each port. He speaks four languages badly and navigates by the taste of salt on the wind. '[STEALTH]'
4. **Kahfagian Customs Agent** — A one-eyed woman with a brass hook for a hand. She stamps cargo with a bell-shaped seal. The seal rings when the declared value is a lie. '[AUTHORITY]'

5. **Oshiiran Grain Auditor** – Thin, spectacled, carries a grain balance. He measures every sack against the Widow's standard. He has found nine thieves this year. The tenth was his own clerk. '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Fog Keeper (Lighthouse)** – An old sailor who lost his sight to a Kahfagian mirror flash. He tends the lamps by touch. He knows which flag flies by the heat of the glass — green is cool, white is warm. '[WEATHER]'

Clubs – Complications (d6)

1. **Tariff Double-Cross** – Both Kahfagia and Oshiira claim the same customs fee. Pay one, and the other impounds your cargo. Pay both, and you are ruined. Smuggle, and you are a patriot. '[WEIGHT]'
2. **Mine Collapse (Sealed Door)** – A cave-in opens a passage to the sealed Aeler door. The miners are afraid. Something is breathing on the other side. The party is asked to investigate — or to seal it again. '[DISASTER]'
3. **Lighthouse Outage** – Both lamps go dark. Ships founder on the reef. The keeper is found dead, one hand on each lamp. The cause of death: old age — or old promises broken. '[DEATH]'
4. **Census Dispute** – Oshiira claims Amaria's population for grain tithes; Kahfagia claims it for port taxes. The same people are counted twice — or not at all. The party is asked to review the records. The records are on fire. '[POLITICS]'
5. **Iron Embargo** – A rival faction sinks an ore barge. Both powers blame each other. The price of iron spikes. The party's cargo is now worth a fortune — and a target. '[COMBAT]'
6. **The Ninth Vein Opens** – The sealed door cracks. A cold wind blows from the deep. The miners flee. A voice whispers a name — the name of the party member who casts the longest shadow. '[MYSTERY]'

Diamonds – Rewards (d6)

1. **Dual Customs Stamp** – One stamp, two seals. Passes both Kahfagian and Oshiiran checkpoints without inspection. Use once per journey. '[TRAVEL]'
2. **Iron Ingot (Ninth Vein)** – A bar of ore from the sealed door's chamber. It is warm to the touch. Aeler runes glow on its surface. Trade it to the True Masons for a favor. '[TRADE]'
3. **Fog Keeper's Log** – A journal of tide and lamp schedules. Decode it to predict when the disputed lighthouse will be unguarded. Gain +1 Position on smuggling attempts. '[WEATHER]'

4. **Twin-Entry Receipt** – A document that proves you paid both tariffs. It is written in disappearing ink. The ink vanishes after one use — but the paper remembers. ‘[JUSTICE]‘
5. **Miner’s Compass** – A brass needle that points to the sealed door. It also points to the nearest iron vein — and to the nearest heart that beats with greed. ‘[TRAVEL]‘
6. **Smuggler’s Flag (Neutral)** – A plain gray banner. Fly it to pass between Kahfagian and Oshiiran patrols unmolested. The patrols will not salute. They will not shoot. They will pretend they did not see you. ‘[STEALTH]‘

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

An empire that never quite died, Ecktoria propped up its marble forums with gilded scaffolding and the stubborn refusal of its undertakers to admit the job is done. The Everflame burns in every basilica – not as a symbol of divine truth, but as a literal lie detector. Swear a false oath near it, and your tongue turns black. The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its steps – and every name left out.

“Ecktoria is a corpse propped up by gilded scaffolding. The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its steps – and every name left out.”

— Marcus of the Red Ledger, Coin-House Factor

What do people eat for breakfast? *Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honey – but only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household’s grain allowance.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count coins by touch. Every Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.*

What is the most common crime? *Tax evasion – but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Censor’s clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is “administrative flexibility.”*

Where do people go when they die? *The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame’s light does not reach that far.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased – legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.*

What is the most important festival? *The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica's central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.*

0.2 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble cracks. The law forgets — but the statues watch.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law is written in marble and witnessed by the flame. Every judgment echoes in the stones — but the stones have grown quiet. The patricians do not listen. They have forgotten what the flame tastes like. They seal their windows with silk and call it governance.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times. The marble remembers the heat. The flame remembers the lies. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other — and at the cracks in their own mirrors. The fire isn’t burning anymore, friend. It’s *smiling*.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, bureaucratic horror, memory as weight, Renaissance decadence — a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles gutter beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-stained fingers offers a folded note. “The Lame King moves tonight. The Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace hasn’t answered a summons in a month. Find out who lit the fire — or the Vigil will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Arena. The statues have been *whispering*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses — but each day, more of its weight slips into the hands of mercenaries and whispers. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with a grief that refuses to name itself.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village's harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce, has threaded their accounts with invisible tolls; every contract they sign forgets a clause. **Livaea**, the demon of desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors — reflections that no longer blink. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* — not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight *feels* like.

The **Vigil** — once the empire's secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution — fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Censer-Knights**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic with brass censers and bells that ring at dawn. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing not coin but *memory* — they collect the names of those who have forgotten what they owe. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. The statues are not decorative. They are the city's *witnesses*.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish — not into death, but into the margins of a record no one will ever read.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread — and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession — and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks. The cracks are where the petitions of the poor are wedged. The cracks are where the Hollow reads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The tallies are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined trust. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract written in water — it will drown you eventually.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers — And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade — it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. But precedent is not justice. Precedent is *memory*, and memory is a weight that the city carries like a cracked keel. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain rolls, and the whispered judgments of the Censor's Hall — and in the *dreams* of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The **Censer-Knights** hunt unlicensed magic; the **Unburnt** hunt sedition; the **Red Vigil** hunts *what was forgotten*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul — and the soul is the city's.

The **patricians** — the Old Blood — no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin — but they have forgotten that the house always wins. The house is the Hollow.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews — not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor's Hall writes in ink that fades when you look away.

The Everflame — Faith of Ash and Incense

The state religion of Ecktoria is a syncretic faith that venerates the Eternal Flame as the divine principle, but its power flows through three great Orders, each devoted to a different Patron. The Basilica of the Unquenched Flame is the heart of the city: a cavernous space of gold mosaics, weeping saints, and the perpetual smell of beeswax and myrrh. Mass is held at dawn and dusk, the congregation coughing through the ash that falls from the censers. The priests sell indulgences in the side chapels — a silver coin for the remission of a small sin, a gold coin for a large one, a horse for a murder. The choir sings in Utaran, a language most parishioners no longer understand, but the melody is beautiful enough to make them weep — and to make the statues turn their heads.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** — The public face of the church. They lead processions, bless marriages, and anoint the dying. Their rites are those of vows, radiance, and protection. They are the ones who light the great candles at dawn. Many are sincere; most are tired. The tired ones are the ones the Vigil watches.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** — The **Censer-Knights**. They hunt untutored magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the flame. Their rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs, and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They are feared, but also respected — for they are the only ones who still take the flame *seriously*. And the flame takes them seriously in return.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** — The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. They are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime — mercy can look like leniency. The common folk love them; the patricians ignore them. The Vigil watches both.

The Everflame is both beautiful and ugly. Its gold leaf covers the same marble where petitioners once scratched their names. Its hymns are sung by choirboys whose families sold them for a loaf of bread. Its relics — a nail from the True Cross, a tear of Saint Lucia — draw pilgrims from across the empire, but the priests charge admission, and the poor sleep on the steps. The flame itself is a wonder: a pillar of blue-white fire that never gutters, tended by the High Priest alone. It is said to show the truth to any who stare into it long enough — and to show the same truth to the Vigil, who watch from the shadows. The truth is always the same: *you have forgotten something*.

At a Glance

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- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame's judgment — but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstræus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List — and the Vigil's three factions, who may arrest you for unpaid weights, sedition, or simply being *remembered*.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent — and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil's own files. The secret is always about a statue.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

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Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.
Flavia	High Priest of the Everflame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea. The silk is warm.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next trust panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying. He does not know who is fraying it.
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters' brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral — the mark of the Red Vigil. The fighter does not know.
The Red Clerk	Censor's Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name. The skull remembers.
Censer-Knight	Commander Vorenius	Prefect of the Order of the Inquisitor Prime	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth. His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not notice the third.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea's favorite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread. She dreams of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

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First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>

Lucius Aelia Honoratus *Flame-Touched*

Tiberius Cornelia Lateranus *the Unburned*

Gaius Livia Silvanus *Bread-Counter*

Decimus Valeria Portinari *Ash-Finger*

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only those who owe.

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- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD PRICE [6]. Patron whispers:* Livaea — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit. They mistake silence for consent.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the tally — but the tally has no god. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers:* Maelstraeus — they measure profit in margins, margins in suffering, and suffering in silver. They do not measure the weight of marble.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe — and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither — the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths. The flame’s truth is ash; the Vigil’s truth is silence.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s weight like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife — and sometimes use it). A wise politician learns to balance all three — and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil — Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other. They also audit the dead.

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- **The Censer-Knights (Orthodox, Everflame)** — Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They answer to the Synod and the High Priest, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* — the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Censer-Knight raid is heralded by a single, low bell. They are the most feared and the most public. They are also the most forgetful. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6]*.
- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** — Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no unpaid toll ever reaches a patrician's ear. They are experts at *redaction* — not killing witnesses, but making them forget. They have forgotten their own names. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6]*.
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus's Own)** — Collectors and enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate — only the record. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound tolls that have grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. They also demand silence — the silence of the forgotten. *Clocks: TOLL DUE [4], ROLL OF NAMES [6]*.

The Vigil's three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late — but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil. The statues know. The statues do not tell.

Spades — Places (revised tone)

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone worn smooth by a thousand hopeful knees. The petitions are written in ink and wax. The steps answer in silence, and the silence is a verdict: "Your claim is under review." A clerk sweeps the steps at dawn. He never reads the petitions. He weighs them. The heaviest goes to the bottom of the pile. The pile is the city's memory.
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late — and the names of those who forgot they owed. The ferrymaster has a brother in the Red Vigil. They do not speak.
4. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels. The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper. The whisper is

always the same: “*I remember. I remember. I remember.*” Those who listen too long forget their own names and start reciting the names of the city’s forgotten dead.

5. **Triumph Stairs** — Marble worn smooth by ambition. The stairs have a name: “The Rise of the Forgotten.” No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them at noon, their retainers counting the steps aloud. They never count to nine. The ninth step is a gap. The gap is where a senator fell — or was pushed — or simply forgot to step. His ghost is still climbing. He has been climbing for a century.
6. **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent. The reagent is made from the tears of the last censor who told the truth. He is still crying.

Heads — People & Factions (revised tone)

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands, knowing every shortcut through the ruins. The ruins are not old. They are last year’s fashionable quarter, abandoned when the mortgage was “reclassified.” She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in the language of eviction notices. She reads them aloud to the rats. The rats pay her in stolen bread.
3. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who “moves” stones. His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. He does not rewrite the map. He rewrites the *memory* of the map. “This street was always a cul-de-sac. You simply forgot.” The Vigil pays him in forgotten names.
4. **Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius** — His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not see the third head. The third head is his own, from a timeline where he kept his oath. It is weeping.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (revised tone)

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A funeral procession for a pauper who died in debt. The law says the corpse cannot cross until the toll is paid. The family has no coin. The law does not accept stories. The corpse is beginning to smell, and the Hollow is beginning to notice a weight that cannot be buried. The Vigil is taking notes on who stops to help.
3. **Border Dispute** — A surveyor has moved a boundary stone three feet east. The new map shows your warehouse now stands on a public thoroughfare. The old map is in the archive. The archive wing collapsed last spring. The memory of the boundary now exists only in the cracked floor of the basilica, and the basilica is accepting sealed bids for “reparative memory.” The Vigil has already bid.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (revised tone)

2. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow. The flame will flicker when you lie. The permit is signed by a clerk who died three years ago. His ghost still signs.
3. **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside. They will leave a note. The note will say: *“We remember. Do you?”*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that turn their heads, flames that burn blue, law that remembers every name — and also echo the **Vigil’s presence**: a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face. The different face is always older. It is always watching.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter — and delivers the wine.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**

- **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** — *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor’s Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
- **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** — *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin — and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
- **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** — *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine’s flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there — and never breaks them.
- **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** — *The Tally Keeper*. A mystery cult of coin-house factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden toll that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their collectors.
- **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** — A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
- **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** — A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties — and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment — but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coin-house weight. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grain-prefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry — but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark those who owe.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three — and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site — the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from

the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take -1 die on your next trust roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor's name into a statue's ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**

- *Aeler True Masons bid* to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
- *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
- *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.

- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**

- If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
- Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
- Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.

- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**

- *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
- *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.
- **Survey Rights** → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s. The Vigil updates the map.

- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**

- Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
- Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
- Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.

- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect *or* -1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Weight* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a roll of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators' mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.

9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors' sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses — and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Weight* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint's chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as tally*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate's Postponement*; add *Karmic Weight* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers:** Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints:** Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers:** Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed rolls offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favor.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-toll in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Re-birth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.
- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Price of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §??)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Counter-coup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. The price will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons:** backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bell-codes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts:** hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners:** war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches — not to stop the rot, but to take notes.

Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every obligation a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening — and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting "safe-conducts," forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage weights surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock [6]** to track which Vigil faction (Censer-Knights, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background — it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature — and they signed in blood long ago.